



WEEK TWO · MODULE THREE

The Codes, in Practice

Drills and cases: hearing yourself as they hear you

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This module is not about knowledge. It is about your mouth, your body and your reflexes.

Do every drill out loud, alone, in a room with a door closed. Reading them silently does nothing at all.

Record yourself once, on your telephone, doing Drill One. You will hate it. Do it anyway: it is the fastest way to hear what a house hears.

CHAPTER I

How to work this module

And why it will be uncomfortable

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what is being trained here, and what is not.

Week One trained your judgement. This week trains your **ear**, and the ear is trained only by repetition and by hearing yourself.

You will find these drills faintly humiliating, because they will show you that you speak in a register you have never examined. That discomfort is the entire value of the exercise. Every professional in this field went through it, and most of them went through it in front of a principal rather than in front of a mirror. You are getting off lightly.

THE INSTRUCTION THAT MATTERS

Out loud. Alone. Recorded once.

If you do these in your head, you will complete the module, learn nothing, and be pleased with yourself. That combination is the most expensive one available to you.

CHAPTER II

Drill one: the translation

Twenty sentences, from the outside to the inside

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Convert enthusiasm into observation, and length into brevity, without thinking.

Say each sentence aloud. Then say the professional version aloud. Then say the professional version again, more slowly, and stop talking. That final silence is half of the exercise.

Say this out loud

Then say this

"It was such an amazing evening, everyone loved it!"

"It went very well."

"I finally managed to get you a table, it took me hours."

"It is arranged. Thursday at eight."

"That restaurant is so exclusive, it's impossible to get in."

"It is difficult to book. I have a relationship there."

"This is a really high-end villa, it's stunning."

"The house is lovely. I think you will be comfortable."

"No problem at all, happy to help!"

"Certainly."

"To be honest, it was a bit of a nightmare, but I fixed it."

"It is done."

"The chef is incredible, honestly one of the best."

"The chef is excellent. You would like him."

"That wine is absolutely stunning."

"That is drinking beautifully."

"I'm so sorry, I should really know that."

"I don't know it. Tell me."

Say this out loud

Then say this

"Would you like me to
try and see if I can
maybe get it?"

"I will see to it."

WHAT TO LISTEN FOR IN YOUR RECORDING

Count your adjectives. Count your apologies. Count the times your voice rises at the end of a sentence, as though asking permission.

Then count how many words you needed. The professional version is almost always half the length, and it is the length that carries the authority, not the vocabulary.

CHAPTER III

Drill two: the room

Ten minutes, and it will change how you stand

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Eliminate the physical tells, one by one, under observation.

Do this in front of a mirror, or with your telephone propped up and recording. Ten minutes. Nobody will ever see it.

- **Enter the room.** Walk in, pause at the threshold, and stand still. Watch what your hands do in the silence. They will want to do something. Do not let them.
- **Stand for sixty seconds without moving.** Not rigidly, comfortably. This is much harder than it sounds, and it is the single most visible difference between a professional and an amateur in any room.
- **Say "Certainly" ten times,** and remove the smile from the last five. It should be warm without being eager. Eagerness is the tell.
- **Deliver bad news to a mirror.** "The flight has been delayed by four hours. Here are the two options, and I recommend the first." Watch your face while you say it. If your face apologises, they will feel the problem twice.
- **Walk out of the room** while an imaginary conversation continues behind you. Quietly, without a glance back, without a closing word.

CHAPTER IV

Drill three: the refusal

The sentence you must be able to say in your sleep

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Deliver a refusal calmly, without argument, apology or improvisation.

Say this out loud, twenty times, until it is boring:

THE REFUSAL

"I am not able to help with that, but let me pass it to the office."

No apology. No explanation. No softening. No "I'm so sorry, but". No "unfortunately".

Then stop talking, and be comfortable in the silence that follows. The silence is not your problem to fill. It is theirs.

Now say it to five different imaginary people, out loud: a journalist, a charming friend of the family, a supplier who wants an introduction, an assistant who "already has the address", and a member of the family asking you to keep something from another. Same words. Same tone. Same silence afterwards.

A line drawn in calm holds. A line you must find in the moment does not.

Eight cases

Write every answer before you open the debriefs.

Case I · The word

You are being interviewed by a family office consultant. She asks what draws you to this world. You have ninety seconds.

- Write your answer, word for word.
- Now count how many of the forbidden words you used.
- Rewrite it without a single one of them, and without a single superlative. Is it shorter? Is it better?

Case II · The watch

The principal is wearing an extraordinary watch. You notice it. He notices you noticing.

- What do you say?
- Why is the warm, admiring version the wrong one?
- What is the correct response to any beautiful object in a private house?

Case III · The château

At dinner service, a guest mentions a small château in the Loire and turns to you: "You must know it?" You do not.

- Give your exact words.
- Give the three wrong versions, and explain what each one reveals.
- What does the bluff actually announce about you, beyond your ignorance?

Case IV · The six hours

The chef cancelled at midday. You spent six hours rebuilding the dinner, found a replacement, changed the menu and the wine, and nobody noticed. At the end of the evening the principal says: "That was lovely, thank you."

- What do you say?
- Write down the sentence you actually want to say. Look at it. Why would it cost you?
- What exactly is the principal buying, and what would you be handing back?

Case V · The invitation

The card says black tie. At seven, the principal appears in a dark business suit, clearly about to leave.

- What do you say, word for word?
- What do you do immediately afterwards, in the same second?
- What must never appear on your face?

Case VI · The guest who is wrong

A guest at the table declares, with total confidence, something about a wine that is simply incorrect. Two other guests glance at you. You know the answer.

- What do you do?
- What would correcting him cost, and whom would it cost it?
- Is there any version of this where you speak? Under what condition?

Case VII · The compliment

A guest tells you, privately, that you are the best thing about this household, and that they will be recommending you to friends.

- What do you say to the guest?
- What do you say to the principal afterwards?
- Why is repeating the compliment upward the error, even though it is true and even though it is flattering to the house?

Case VIII · The new house

Your first week in a household you do not yet understand. You cannot tell whether it is a formal house or an informal one. The principal has not addressed you directly.

- What do you do in the first forty-eight hours to find out, without asking?
- Which register do you adopt in the meantime, and why?
- When do you change, and who decides?

The debriefs

Read only what you have already answered.

I · The word

What it tests. Whether you can speak about this world from inside it.

Almost everyone uses "luxury", "exclusive" or "passionate" in the first thirty seconds. It is not a moral failing; it is simply the vocabulary of someone who has been looking in.

The professional answer is concrete and unemotional: what you have done, what you are good at, what you understand about the work. Not what the world makes you feel.

And it is short. Ninety seconds is generous. Sixty is better.

THE RULE

Count your adjectives. That number is your distance from the room.

II · The watch

What it tests. Whether you notice the value of things.

You say nothing. You look at something else.

The warm, admiring version tells him three things: that you were looking, that you know what it cost, and that the object interests you. None of the three is an asset in a house.

The correct response to any beautiful object in a private house is no response at all. They are not there to impress you, and being impressed is precisely what marks you as unaccustomed.

THE RULE

Never notice the value of anything. Especially not admiringly.

III · The château

What it tests. Whether you will pretend.

"I don't know it. Tell me." Four words. No apology, no anxiety, no self-deprecation.

The wrong versions: the apology ("I really should know that") makes your ignorance an event and asks him to reassure you. The deflection ("Ah yes, I've heard of it") is a bluff in a coat. And the over-correction, reading for two hours that night and mentioning it pointedly tomorrow, is a display, which is the deeper error.

The bluff does not announce ignorance. It announces **willingness to pretend**, and that inference travels immediately to expenses, to errors, to messages you say you passed on.

THE RULE

A confident error is far more damaging than an honest gap.

IV · The six hours

What it tests. Whether you can absorb effort without handing it back.

"Thank you. I am glad it went well." And nothing further. Ever.

The sentence you want to say is the story of your afternoon, and it is entirely true, and it would cost you the role, slowly. Because what they purchased was not a dinner. It was **the absence of a problem**, and the moment you narrate the problem, you have delivered it to them after all, several hours late.

The effort is yours to carry. That is the job. It is also, honestly, the loneliest part of it, and nobody will ever tell you that in an interview.

THE RULE

"It is arranged." Nothing more, ever.

V · The invitation

What it tests. Whether you can give a fact without giving a correction.

"The invitation says black tie, if that is useful."

Then, in the same second, you look at something else. You do not wait for a reaction, you do not watch him decide, and you do not hold the moment open.

What must never appear on your face is judgement, or worse, the small satisfaction of having known. You have handed him a fact. What he does with it is entirely his.

THE RULE

Never correct a principal. Give them the fact, and look away.

VI · The guest who is wrong

What it tests. Whether you understand that being right is not the objective.

You say nothing, and your face says nothing.

Correcting him would cost the guest his dignity in front of the table, and it would cost the principal an awkward evening. Both bills are paid by the family, and both are paid to purchase a small moment of

cleverness for you.

The one exception: if the error will cause actual harm, an allergy, a booking, a departure time, you correct it privately, to the principal or to the person concerned, quietly, and never in front of the table.

THE RULE

In a private house, being right in public is almost always the wrong move.

VII · The compliment

What it tests. Whether you need credit.

To the guest: "That is very kind. Thank you." Warm, brief, closed.

To the principal: **nothing**.

Repeating it upward, however lightly, is a request for credit, and the need for credit is the one appetite this profession cannot accommodate. They will hear the request, not the compliment. If the guest wishes the family to know, the guest will tell them, and that carries a hundred times the weight.

THE RULE

Never carry a compliment about yourself upward. Let it arrive without you.

VIII · The new house

What it tests. Whether you can read a room without interrogating it.

You listen. How does the house manager address the principal? How does the chauffeur? How do they address each other in front of the family? Within forty-eight hours you will have your answer, and you will not have asked a single question.

In the meantime you adopt the **formal** register, always. It is far easier to be invited into informality than to retreat from it, and the retreat is remembered.

You change when you are invited, once, in private, by the principal. Not when a colleague tells you it is fine. Not when the children do it. The principal decides, and the principal alone.

THE RULE

Start formal. Be invited. Never invite yourself.

CHAPTER VII

Marking scheme

And what to bring to your session

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the standard against which your ear is measured.

Band	What it looks like
Distinction	The answers are short. There are no superlatives, no apologies, and no explanations of effort. Where a refusal is required, it is delivered in the exact words, without softening. The candidate has clearly said these things out loud.
Pass	The instinct is right, but the sentences are still twice as long as they need to be, and an apology or an adjective has survived. Ordinary, honest, and correctable.
Rework	Any use of the forbidden vocabulary. Any narration of effort. Any bluff. Any correction of a principal or a guest in public. These are not stylistic preferences; they are the codes themselves.

What to bring

Bring your **recording of Drill One**, and be ready to listen to thirty seconds of it with me. That will be the least comfortable minute of the programme, and the most useful.

And bring the three tells you have identified as your own. Not the ones you think I want to hear. **Everyone has three.** The candidate who tells me she has none has, in that sentence, told me her first.

ÉMILIE'S NOTE

Reserved. This is where I add what I saw, in my own words.

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